

How to write formal emails to your colleges when inquiring about something/ asking for a fee waiver, etc. (Or writing an email to anyone at all about anything, really)

- THE SUBJECT LINE IS IMPORTANT! Please do not send an email without a subject line, it will be ignored. Here, summarize your reason for writing as much as possible.
- Generally, this is the form emails should take, but of course, there are variations depending on the message in the body.
- You can flip “Hello” with “ Good morning”, “Good afternoon” etc. but always ensure that they are followed by a comma.
- The first paragraph is usually for introduction/salutation.
- The second paragraph carries the intent of writing/ what do you want to know/ what do you need help with, etc.
- The last line is just a nice finish. It ends the email on a positive note e.g. Have a nice weekend!
- For the valediction, you can sign off with “Kind regards”, “Regards”, “Best wishes”, “Best”, “Yours sincerely” etc. depending on your relationship with the recipient.

Best practices when writing an email to the college

- 1) Ensure you write a subject line. This is a summary of your predicament, concern, or question.
Examples of subject lines are:
 - *Concerning Admission Checklist*
 - *Missing School Report*
 - *Application Requirements for the Penn Dual Degree Program*
 - *Request for CSS Fee Waiver*
 - *Request for Non-Custodial Parent Waiver*
 - *Custodial Parent Non-Tax Filer*
 - *School Testing Policy*
- 2) Remember to introduce yourself because they have no idea who you are. Are you an international student? Are you applying as a freshman or a transfer student? That sort of thing.
- 3) Use formal language and be respectful. Note that you are talking to someone who is older than you.
- 4) Remember that you and the person responding to the email are in different time zones. So if you decide to say Good morning, Good afternoon, or Good evening, ensure that at the time you are sending the email, it is morning, afternoon, or evening (respectively) at their time zone. This is just being mindful.

- 5) Make it brief. Go straight to the point, ensuring you have mentioned exactly what you want from them. You don't need to write a long communication.
- 6) Send in attachments whenever you need to. Sometimes in order for you to be understood well, you need to show them exactly what you mean. Feel free to send screenshots if you think it will explain your situation better. However, remember to say that you have attached a screenshot to the email.
- 7) End your emails with a valediction such as Regards, Kind regards, Yours sincerely, etc. followed by your full name.

Here are some examples:

Re: School Testing Policy

Good morning,

I hope this email finds you well.

I am a student from Nairobi, Kenya and I'm applying to Duke University in the Early Decision cycle.

I am writing to inquire about the school testing policy. Is submitting test scores an application requirement?

**Regards,
Faith Njambi Wandati,
Prospective student.**

Subject: Custodial Parent Non-Tax Filer

Good afternoon,

I hope this email finds you well.

I have just submitted my financial aid application. However, I cannot provide my mother's tax documents because her earnings are below the taxable income amount.

Are there any documents that I can provide in place of these? Kindly advise me on this matter.

**Kind regards,
Ivan Mutua Kioko**

Subject: Non-Custodial Parent Waiver

Good afternoon,

I hope this email finds you well.

I am currently preparing my financial aid application. I noticed that I am required to provide both of my parents' financial information. However, I cannot provide any information on my father because my parents separated in 2010, and I have not contacted him since.

I have completed the College Board NCP waiver form and I can provide it alongside third-party documentation to explain my situation with my father (attached to this email). Do let me know if this will be satisfactory, or whether I'll be needed to provide anything else.

**Yours sincerely,
Olga Atieno**